FRAM SCHOOL

CAMBRIDGE International Education

Cambridge International School

FRAM Primary School

No.4 Berăriei Street, Habermann Square
Tel.: +40724491440, +0727786400
E-mail:administrative@framschool.com

NAVIGATE YOUR OWN JOURNEYS OF LEARNING AND SELF-DISCOVERY IN AN EXCITING FUTURE

FRAM PHYSICAL CONTACT POLICY

1. Introduction and Purpose

Creating a safe, respectful, and culturally sensitive environment is foundational to our educational community. Physical interactions between staff and students, particularly touches such as hugs, guiding gestures, or supportive contact - are natural and often vital components of caring and effective pedagogy. However, in diverse international settings, attitudes and norms surrounding physical contact can vary widely, and the potential for misunderstandings or misinterpretations necessitates clear guidelines and boundaries.

The purpose of this policy is to establish a comprehensive framework for responsible physical contact and professional conduct. It aims to protect the well-being and dignity of children, ensure staff are equipped with knowledge and best practices, and uphold a culture of trust, safety, and respect within our educational community. This policy provides guidance on when and how physical interactions such as hugging should be approached, emphasizing safeguarding, cultural sensitivity, and professionalism at all times.

2. Alignment to School Values and Commitment

Our core values - ***kindness, respect, fairness, awareness, and leadership*** - are the foundation of our approach to diversity and inclusion. We believe that embracing and respecting individual differences enriches our educational community and promotes social cohesion.

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Core Principles

- Children's Bodily Integrity and Autonomy:
  Respect each child's right to personal safety, bodily autonomy, and comfort. Physical contact should always be appropriate, brief, supportive, and guided by the child's cues and individual needs.
- Cultural Sensitivity:
  Recognize that norms regarding touch vary widely across cultures. Every staff member should understand and respect the diverse backgrounds of students and colleagues.
- Professional Boundaries:
  Maintain appropriate, transparent boundaries in interactions. Physical contact must be limited to supportive or educational gestures that are non-sexual, brief, and occur in public or monitored settings.
- Safety and Safeguarding:
  Protect children from harm, misunderstanding, or false allegations. All interactions involving physical contact should promote safety, trust, and respect.

Guidelines for Responsible Physical Contact (Including Hugging and Positioning)

1. Use of Hugging and Physical Contact:

- **When appropriate:** Hugs can be a caring gesture when used thoughtfully and only when the child has given clear permission—verbally or through cues—and when culturally appropriate.
- **Position during physical contact:** Always ensure that physical contact, especially during hugs or supportive gestures, does not involve making contact with a child's private areas (e.g., chest, groin, thighs).
- **Lowering oneself:** To maintain boundaries and safety, educators should position themselves at the child's eye level when giving a hug. This can be achieved by kneeling or sitting to avoid looking down on children or reaching above their upper

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body, thereby reducing the risk of unintentional or inappropriate contact with private areas.

- **Duration and manner:** Keep hugs brief - just a few seconds, gentle, and non-intrusive. Once the gesture has served its purpose, gently conclude the contact and step back to maintain a professional distance.
- **Environmental context:** Avoid hugging children in private settings or secluded areas where others cannot observe interactions. Maintain visibility to foster transparency and safety.
- **Respect the child's comfort:** Never force a child into physical contact or pressure them if they show disinterest or discomfort. Support their understanding of body autonomy and boundaries through age-appropriate conversations.

2. General Conduct During Physical Contact:

- **Use physical touch primarily to show care**, reassurance, or support—never for disciplinary purposes.
- **Always anticipate how a gesture might be perceived by others** and whether it aligns with the child's individual comfort and cultural background.
- **Be particularly cautious with male staff members**, ensuring any physical contact follows strict guidelines to prevent misunderstandings.

3. When to Avoid Contact:

- **Private or secluded interactions** that cannot be observed.
- **Prolonged, forceful, or intrusive contact**, especially if the child resists or shows signs of discomfort.
- **Physical contact used as punishment or discipline.**
- Touch involving private body areas.

4. Monitoring and Environment:

- **Conduct interactions in open, visible, or monitored areas whenever possible**.
- **When engaging in one-on-one activities,** inform another adult when appropriate or conduct the interaction in a public space with clear visibility, ensuring the child's safety and comfort.

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Professional Conduct Toward Colleagues and Parents

- **Respect colleagues' and parents' personal boundaries;** avoid inappropriate language, behaviors, or gestures.
- Communicate respectfully and professionally, especially in electronic communication, and seek permission before sharing photos, videos, or personal information.
- Report any concerns or incidents regarding physical contact or misconduct immediately following safeguarding procedures.

Digital and Social Media Use

- **Refrain from sharing images or information of children or colleagues** without explicit permission.
- Maintain confidentiality and professional integrity in all online interactions.

Additional Expectations

- Adhere to the school's dress code, promoting an appropriate, professional appearance.
- Engage in ongoing professional development on safeguarding, cultural competence, and boundary awareness.
- Uphold integrity, honesty, and transparency in all professional activities.

Implementation and Monitoring

- All staff will receive training on this policy during onboarding and regularly thereafter.
- Managers and leaders will model best practices and oversee adherence.
- Any incidents, concerns, or breaches will be evaluated and addressed promptly through established safeguarding and disciplinary protocols.

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